

The Best Foods to Eat for Arthritis: Your Anti-Inflammatory

Evidence-based foods that fight joint inflammation and support long-term arthritis management.

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There is no magic food that cures arthritis. But there is robust and growing evidence that what you put on your plate has a direct effect on systemic inflammation — the underlying mechanism behind most forms of joint disease. Adding the right foods to your diet is just as important as removing the wrong ones.



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This article brings together the best-evidenced anti-inflammatory foods for people living with arthritis in the UK. It covers practical ways to incorporate them into a British diet without expensive ingredients or complicated recipes. Whether you have osteoarthritis, rheumatoid arthritis, psoriatic arthritis, or ankylosing spondylitis, an anti-inflammatory eating pattern can make a real difference.

The Anti-Inflammatory Diet Principle

The Mediterranean diet is the most studied dietary pattern for arthritis and inflammation. Rich in plant foods, oily fish, olive oil, and whole grains, it has been shown in multiple clinical trials to reduce CRP (C-reactive protein, a key inflammation marker), lower TNF-alpha levels, and improve pain and function scores in people with RA and OA.

You do not need to move to Greece to benefit. The principles — more vegetables, more fish, more olive oil, less processed food — translate perfectly to a UK shopping basket.



1. Oily Fish

Oily fish — salmon, mackerel, sardines, herring, trout, and anchovies — are the single most powerful anti-inflammatory food you can add to your arthritis diet. They are the richest natural sources of long-chain omega-3 fatty acids EPA and DHA, which suppress inflammatory cytokines and reduce joint tenderness and morning stiffness.

UK guidance recommends eating at least two portions of fish per week, one of which should be oily. For arthritis management, aiming for three to four portions weekly is reasonable. Tinned sardines, mackerel, and salmon are budget-friendly options widely available in UK supermarkets and just as nutritious as fresh fish.

****Easy UK meal ideas**** - Tinned sardines on wholegrain toast — quick, cheap, and rich in omega-3. - Grilled salmon fillet with sweet potato and steamed broccoli. - Smoked mackerel pâté with oatcakes and cucumber.



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2. Extra-Virgin Olive Oil

Extra-virgin olive oil (EVOO) is a cornerstone of the Mediterranean diet and arguably the most important fat for people with arthritis. It contains oleocanthal, a polyphenol that inhibits COX-1 and COX-2 enzymes — the same enzymes blocked by ibuprofen. Research from the University of Pennsylvania calculated that 3.4 tablespoons of EVOO provides anti-inflammatory activity equivalent to approximately 10% of a standard ibuprofen dose.

EVOO also contains hydroxytyrosol and oleuropein, potent antioxidants that protect joint tissue from oxidative stress. Use EVOO as your primary cooking fat, in salad dressings, and drizzled over cooked vegetables. Choose bottles labelled 'cold-pressed' and 'first cold extraction' for maximum polyphenol content.

3. Leafy Green Vegetables

Spinach, kale, Swiss chard, rocket, and spring greens are nutritional powerhouses for arthritis. They are rich in antioxidants — including vitamins C and E, and the carotenoids lutein and zeaxanthin — that neutralise the free radicals produced during inflammation, protecting cartilage and synovial tissue from further damage.

Kale and spinach are also excellent sources of vitamin K, which plays a role in bone metabolism and may slow OA progression. A Harvard study found that people with the highest vitamin K intakes had significantly lower rates of knee and hip OA. Aim for two to three portions of leafy greens per day, either raw in salads or lightly steamed.

4. Berries and Cherries

Berries are among the richest dietary sources of anthocyanins — the dark red and blue pigments that give blueberries, blackberries, and cherries their colour. Anthocyanins are potent antioxidants that have been shown to inhibit inflammatory enzymes and reduce CRP levels.

Tart cherry, in particular, has remarkable evidence for gout. Multiple randomised controlled trials have shown that tart cherry juice or concentrate significantly reduces gout flare frequency and lowers serum uric acid levels. A study published in **Arthritis and Rheumatism** found that two servings of cherries per day were associated with a 35% lower risk of gout attacks. Fresh or frozen blueberries, strawberries, and blackcurrants provide similar anthocyanin benefits for other arthritis types.

5. Walnuts and Other Nuts

Walnuts are unique among nuts in that they are an excellent plant-based source of ALA (alpha-linolenic acid), the precursor to omega-3 fatty acids. They also contain ellagic acid, an anti-inflammatory polyphenol. A study in the **Journal of the American College of Nutrition** found that people with RA who consumed walnuts regularly reported lower disease activity scores.

Other beneficial nuts include almonds (rich in vitamin E, which protects joint membranes from oxidative damage), Brazil nuts (rich in selenium, a deficiency of which is associated with increased RA activity), and pistachios. A small handful — about 30g — five times per week is a practical and cost-effective target.

6. Garlic, Onions, and the Allium Family

Garlic, onions, leeks, and spring onions belong to the allium family and contain diallyl disulfide, a compound that inhibits the activity of pro-inflammatory cytokines including IL-17. Research from King's College London found that women who regularly ate a diet rich in alliums had significantly less hip OA than those who did not.

Garlic is also a powerful antimicrobial and prebiotic, supporting the gut microbiome — increasingly recognised as a key modulator of systemic inflammation. Use fresh garlic liberally in cooking, and do not overlook leeks and onions as anti-inflammatory staples.

7. Pulses and Legumes

Lentils, chickpeas, black beans, kidney beans, and peas are fibre-rich, plant-based proteins that support a healthy gut microbiome and provide a slow, sustained energy release that avoids the blood sugar spikes associated with inflammation. They are also rich in folate, magnesium, and iron — nutrients important for joint and bone health.

UK arthritis charities recommend two to three portions of pulses per week. Tinned chickpeas and lentils are convenient, affordable, and nutritionally equivalent to dried versions. Add them to curries, soups, stews, and salads for a practical, anti-inflammatory protein boost.

8. Green Tea

Green tea contains epigallocatechin-3-gallate (EGCG), one of the most potent polyphenols studied for arthritis. Laboratory studies show EGCG inhibits the production of inflammatory cytokines and matrix metalloproteinases — enzymes that break down cartilage. Human studies have found associations between habitual green tea consumption and lower rates of RA and OA in Asian populations.

Three to four cups of green tea per day provides a meaningful dose of EGCG. Matcha powder, which contains the whole ground tea leaf, delivers roughly ten times the EGCG of a regular green tea bag. Avoid adding milk, which may bind the polyphenols and reduce absorption.

Quick Answer

The best foods for arthritis are oily fish (salmon, mackerel, sardines), extra-virgin olive oil, leafy green vegetables (spinach, kale), berries and tart cherries, walnuts, garlic and onions, pulses

and legumes, and green tea. These foods reduce inflammation, protect joint tissue, and are backed by clinical research.

Building Your Anti-Arthritis Plate

A practical target: fill half your plate with colourful vegetables at every meal, include oily fish three times per week, use olive oil instead of butter or vegetable oil, snack on a small handful of walnuts or berries, and drink green tea in place of one or two daily coffees. Small, consistent changes compounded over weeks and months produce lasting results.

Conclusion

The best foods to eat for arthritis share a common theme: they are whole, minimally processed, and rich in anti-inflammatory compounds. An evidence-based eating pattern centred on oily fish, olive oil, colourful vegetables, berries, nuts, and pulses can meaningfully reduce pain, lower inflammation markers, and protect joint tissue over time. Pair these dietary changes with your prescribed treatment, regular appropriate exercise, and regular GP reviews for the best possible outcome.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about the best foods to eat for arthritis: your anti-inflammatory ?

Short answer: For arthritis management, aim for an anti-inflammatory diet rich in oily fish, extra-virgin olive oil, leafy green vegetables, berries, walnuts, and alliums like garlic. Oily fish like salmon and mackerel provide omega-3s, while EVOO contains anti-inflammatory oleocanthal. These foods can help reduce inflammation and improve joint health.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk